

Ceres,
goddess
of the
harvest



Cloak

Chiton,
or full
tunic

Culture

Ancient Greek art and science was of the highest standard, and set the standard for European culture for centuries. "Greece, though conquered," wrote the Roman poet Horace, "brought the arts to the uncivilized Latin peoples" (Romans) – and through them to modern Europe.

Sculpture

Ancient Greek sculpture was famous for its naturalness, beauty, and perfect proportions. Statues related to all aspects of life, including religious worship and sport. Those of deities, such as Ceres, were popular among farmers, and were left at shrines to ensure a good harvest.

Drama and architecture

The ancient Greeks learned much from the Egyptians about using stone in their architecture – but their theatres were original. In the golden age of Athens (400s BC), dramatists, such as Aeschylus, Sophocles, and Euripides wrote tragedies that are still performed.

Epidaurus theatre



Amphora

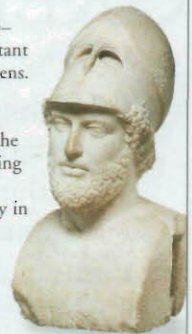
Human
figures at
a banquet

Art

Red-figure painting replaced black-figure in c.530 BC. Most red-figure vases (amphorae) were made from Athenian clay. Subjects were usually male, and were often shown banqueting or engaged in athletics.

Pericles

From 443 BC, Pericles (c.495–429 BC) was the most important politician and general in Athens. A great public speaker and champion of democracy, he strengthened and expanded the Athenian empire after defeating the Persians. He also made Athens the most splendid city in Greece by arranging for the Parthenon and other buildings to be built on the Acropolis, a rocky hill overlooking the city.



Language and literature

Ancient Greek, like Latin, is known as a "classical" language. Many great works of Greek literature have survived by authors such as Hesiod and Apollonius (poets), Thucydides (a historian), and Plato (a philosopher).

Greek inscription of thanks to Asclepius, the god of medicine



Alphabet

The word "alphabet" (used in many modern languages, including English) was formed by joining the first two letters of ancient Greek: alpha and beta. The Cyrillic alphabet of eastern Europe also grew out of the Greek alphabet.

Greek-Persian wars

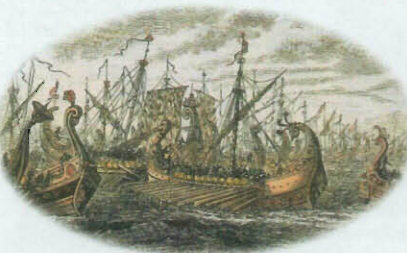
After 545 BC, the mighty Persian Empire took over Greek cities in Ionia, the easternmost part of Greek territory. When Athens tried to lend support to the cities (499–494 BC), the Persians invaded mainland Greece, but were driven back at Marathon. Ten years later, an alliance between Athens, Sparta, and other Greek cities defeated another massive Persian expedition on land and sea at Salamis.



The Treasury, Delphi

Battle of Marathon

In 490 BC, a Persian force sailed across the Aegean Sea, and landed in Attica. On the plain of Marathon, against all odds, it was heavily defeated by an army of Athenians and their allies. The Athenians built a treasury at Delphi to mark this victory, filled it with Persian spoils, and dedicated it to Apollo, the god of war.

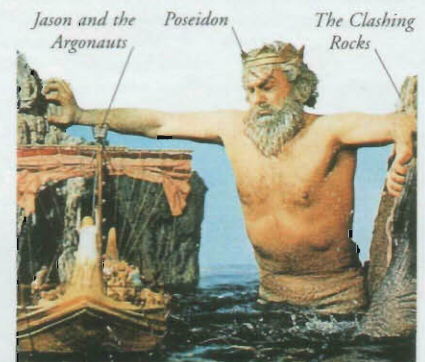


Battle of Salamis

In 480 BC, the Persian emperor Xerxes the Great led a huge force along the shores of the Aegean Sea. As central Greece fell, the Athenians evacuated their city. A smaller Greek fleet then lured the Persians into battle in the straits between the mainland and the island of Salamis – and defeated them decisively.

Philip of Macedon

Warrior-king Philip II ruled Macedon, a northern state in Greece, from 359 to 336 BC. A strong king and a great diplomat, Philip made Macedon the dominant power in the Greek world. He was murdered on the point of invading Persia, but by then had laid the foundations for his son, Alexander, to continue his military feats.



Jason and the Argonauts

Even today, Greek myths are rewritten, and made into plays and films. Few tales are as dramatic as the quest by Jason and his ship, the *Argo*, to steal the Golden Fleece of the Sun from a watchful dragon. On their journey, Jason and his crew (including the hero Heracles) were helped and hindered by many gods, monsters, witches, and giants.

Timeline

c.2700–1120 BC
Mycenaean civilization flourishes.

c.750–550 BC Greeks
colonize areas in Italy
and Africa.

560–510 BC Athenian
influence spreads.



Detail from amphora

510 BC Cleisthenes, an Athenian statesman, introduces democracy to Athens.

c.510–366 BC
Peloponnesian League
forms, led by Sparta.

499–494 BC Revolt against
Persia by Ionian Greeks.

490 BC Battle of
Marathon.

480–479 BC Greeks
repel Persian invaders
at Salamis and Plataea.

477 BC Athens and
Ionian Greeks form
Delian League
against Persia.

459 BC Sparta defeats
Athens in first
Peloponnesian War.

443–429 BC
Pericles dominant
in Athens.

431–404 BC Sparta
wins second, or Great,
Peloponnesian War.



378–371 BC Thebes
overthrows Sparta as
leading Greek power.

359–323 BC Reigns of
Philip II and his son
Alexander the Great
of Macedon.

Hephaistos, god of fire

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